ABHY Web Portal Material

project development objectives

project objective :

To improve the extent, quality, and accessibility of ground water resources and its management through a planned process.

project beneficiaries :

The recipients of ABHY are the economies, occupations, and social orders that depend upon ground water assets for flourishing and wellbeing. The arrest in decline of ground water levels is likely to improve water regimes required for agriculture, domestic, and industrial purposes, thereby generating societal benefit. In particular, it will have positive impacts on -

- Women, small marginal farmers, and agricultural labourers
- Central and state government agencies responsible for ground water management
- Population affected by floods and droughts, particularly poor people living in the rural areas
- Environment and agriculture ministries; research and educational institutions; NGOs; civil society organizations; students and researchers; and the private sector

key result indicators :

- **Result Area 1 - Improved planning and implementation of ground water management interventions.** Activities under Result Area 1 will focus on (a) introducing bottom-up planning of ground water interventions through community-led Water Security Plans (WSPs), (b) improving government spending through a planned process, and (c) implementing participatory ground water management, including both supply and demand side measures.
- **Result Area 2 - Strengthened institutional framework and effective ground water data monitoring and disclosure.** Result Area 2 focuses on building institutional capacity at all levels, including improving ground water information and making it publicly accessible. Activities will include building institutional capacity at the central and state levels by ensuring that staff are adequately trained to effectively manage ground water resources.

Project implementation

Overview of implementing agencies

1. Central level : At the central level, the primary responsibility for ground water management lies with the CGWB under the MoWR, RD&GR. Its mandate is to develop and disseminate technologies and monitor and implement national policies for scientific and sustainable development of ground water resources, including their exploration, assessment, conservation, augmentation, and protection from pollution and distribution.

2. **State level.** At the state level, the nodal agencies for ground water management are typically housed within Water Resource Departments, Agriculture Departments, and Departments of Public Health and Engineering. They primarily focus on ground water resource estimation and monitoring in the selected states. The ground water agencies of the concerned states are as follows :

- **Gujarat. -** Gujarat Water Resources Development Corporation Limited under the Department of Water Resources
- **Haryana. -** Ground Water Cell under the Department of Agriculture
- **Karnataka -** State Ground Water Directorate under the Water Resources Department
- **Madhya Pradesh -** Ground Water Division under the State Water Resources Department
- **Maharashtra -** Ground Water Surveys and Development Agency
- **Rajasthan -** Ground Water Directorate under the Public Health Engineering Department

- **Uttar Pradesh -** Ground Water Department (Minor Irrigation and Ground Water)

3. District level. The district level institutional apparatus consists of institutions present at the district, block, and village level. These are collectively known as Panchayati Raj Institution (PRIs) and play a critical role because they are one of the key institutions through which many national programs such as MGNREGA, PMKSY and so on are implemented at the field. PRIs also have significant powers to decide how funds will be allocated for various uses and are in some cases responsible for implementation of on-the-ground investments, in addition to the monitoring of program implementation.

Strategy for implementation arrangements :

The vast majority of Program implementation will be the responsibility of the state, district and block governments; gram panchayats (GPs); and communities. Implementation arrangements are designed to promote the use of existing structures at all levels and to promote coordination between various agencies and tiers of government. The approaches include-

- Foundation of national and state level inter-agency Steering Committees for better coordination between ground water departments and agencies.

- Disbursement of funds to the states based on achievement.

- Hiring of Technical Support Agencies (TSAs) at the national and state level and Support Organisations (SOs) to bridge capacity gaps and build capacity in public institutions and

- Development of an integrated Management Information System (MIS) that increases the flow of information and eases the implementation of standardised Program procedures.

Project Implementation, Management and Coordination

At the central level, a Program Management Unit (PMU) has been established in the MoWR, RD&GR to implement the Program. It will be responsible for program planning and coordination across various state implementing agencies; Financial Management (FM) and procurement of central activities; monitoring of social and environmental aspects; Monitoring and Evaluation (M&E); and communications. The PMU will also provide support to the state implementing agencies upon demand. The PMU will be supported in carrying out its functions by a national level Technical Support Agency (TSA) whose main task will be conducting a national communications campaign to promote the behavioural changes required under the Program.

A national level Steering Committee will oversee the Program implementation and resolve any coordination issues across agencies or tiers of government that cannot be resolved by the PMU. The Steering Committee will be chaired by the Secretary, the MoWR, RD&GR; and include as its members Chairman, CGWB; Chairman, Central Water Commission; Commissioner (state project/PMKSY director); Joint Secretary and Financial Advisor, MoWR, RD&GR; and Director of PMU. Membership of the Steering Committee also includes the secretaries from the Ministries of Agriculture, Rural Development, and Drinking Water Supply and Sanitation.

State level Steering Committees for ground water management will be established in each of the seven Participating States to oversee state and local level implementation of the program and coordinate between various state agencies. Each state has been assigned a nodal agency for the ABHY Program. State level Program Implementation Agencies (PIAs) in the nodal agency have already been established to implement the Program. The PIAs will be responsible for technical, environmental and social, FM, procurement, and administrative aspects of program implementation and monitoring at the state level. The PIA will be staffed by a team of experts, including technical specialists, environmental and social specialists, procurement and FM specialists, and M&E specialists. A key responsibility of the PIA will be to ensure that adequate and need based support is provided at the local level to prepare and implement Water Security Plans (WSPs).

At the district level, existing district, block and Gram Panchayat (GP) government institutions will be responsible for implementing the Program at their own levels. Implementation responsibilities include the preparation of WSPs and the implementation of district and community level interventions from WSPs. Nodal agencies are already present in all program districts through their divisional level units (DPIUs). The state PIA supported by the TSA will hire the requisite number of Support Organisations (SOs) to facilitate community participation in preparing and implementing WSPs. The SOs will work hand in hand with DPIUs to ensure that the GPs and Water Users Association (WUAs) or other village level committees build their knowledge and capacity over time on participatory management practices, including preparing WSPs and implementing community level interventions.

project description

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Atal Bhujal Yojana (ABHY) also known as National Ground Water Management Improvement Scheme (NGMIS), aims to improve ground water management in priority areas in the country through community participation. It underscores the need to improve ground water information accessibility, sharing and use. Recognising that the fate of ground water resources ultimately relies upon how resources are utilized and managed at the local level, the Program is anchored in planning and managing ground water resources led by an informed community.

ABHY is designed to operationalise the results orientation of the plan by incentivising the Participating States to improve planning, implementation of investments and ground water management actions to arrest the decline of ground water levels and strengthen ground water institutions at all levels. The Program aims to rebalance the approach of ground water management by encouraging demand side and effective supply side measures. It is expected that these measures will show early success and provide a solid foundation, paving the way for broader institutional reforms in the longer run.

A four pronged strategy :

- **Decision support tools for ground water management :** An MIS is being developed to operationalise and standardise program implementation across the Participating States. The MIS will be used to operationalise and standardise the preparation of Water Security Plans (WSPs), water budgeting, monitoring of ground water levels and quality, and reporting on the progress in implementation of WSPs. The MIS will be extensively used by implementing agencies at all levels. It will provide access to information for beneficiary communities to plan and implement interventions.

- **Strengthen community based institutions to foster management :** The incentives provided under ABHY will trigger initiatives to strengthen enabling institutions and build the required information base for bottom-up, participatory planning and implementation of appropriate interventions in ground water management and use. This represents a step change in the 'business-as-usual' approach and will set the correct course to accomplish sustainable ground water management at a larger scale.

- **Improve water use efficiency and enhance ground water recharge :** The Program supports volumetric metering and real-time data systems, as well as raising awareness about the importance of good ground water governance. It also supports on-ground actions that are based on community ownership and judicious management of water resources.

- **Fiscal decentralisation :** The program not only focuses on building state institutions but also supports the general move of the Government of India (GoI) towards fiscal decentralisation. It takes forward the GWMR Scheme, a centrally implemented scheme that does not allocate funds to the state level. This centralised approach has affected ownership, uptake, and implementation of the Aquifer Management Plan (AMPs). In ABHY, funds are to flow from the central government to the states and from there onwards to the appropriate implementing levels (districts, blocks, GPs, and beneficiaries).

Appraisal summary

technical

ABHY would extend and improve the quality of ground water monitoring network and the assessment and utilization of monitoring data. It will help in building a comprehensive database that incorporates ground water data availability and quality, as well as its demand on the resource base.

The Program would also incentivise the advancement of information accumulation and sharing mechanisms between central and state agencies. This would empower the dispersal of annual ground water status reports required for improved participatory ground water management.

financial manager

ABHY is relied upon to acquire consistency in the fund flows (including transfers, advances, and banking) and expenditure filing systems with the help of Government of India's (GoI's) online Expenditure, Advance, and Transfer (EAT) Module in the Public Financial Management System (PFMS) for all the implementing agencies. In the event that this framework is not utilized by all the implementing agencies, there is a risk that fiduciary monitoring and oversight and consolidation of financial information may weaken significantly. It is proposed that the use of the PFMS by all implementing agencies will be mandatory under ABHY, and any expenditure not entered in the PFMS/EAT will not be considered as Program expenditure.